OCTOBER 1993

AFRICAN SUN

Historical Events - October

__1966- The Black Panther Party is founded in Oakland, CA by Huey Newton and Bobby Seale. Insisting on "power to the people," This group advocated self-defense, called for a socialist economy, and provided food and educational programs to young children.

1, 1960- Nigerian Independence Day. Nigeria declares its independence from Great Britain. It also became a republic exactly two years later.

3, 1974- Frank Robinson is named manager for the Cleveland Indians, becoming the first Black manager in the history of Major League Baseball.

3, 1989- Hall of Famer and former Oakland Raider, Art Shell, is named Head Coach of the Los Angeles Raiders, making him the first Black Head Coach in the National Football League.

7, 1897- Robert Poole, later known as the Honorable Elijah Muhammed, was born in Sanderville, GA. Favoring the formation of an all-Black state or territory in the United States, Muhammed was the leader of the Black Muslims.

12, 1950- Dr. Ronald E. McNair was born in Lake City, S.C. McNair was the mission specialist on the space shuttle Challenger, which exploded 74 seconds after lift-off in 1986.

14, 1964- Martin Luther King, Jr., age 35, becomes the youngest man ever to win the Nobel Peace Prize.

17, 1988- Pearl Bailey is awarded the Presidential Medal of Freedom, the nation's highest civilian award for her significant cultural achievements.

18, 1977- Reggie Jackson of the New York Yankees hits three home runs in a single World Series game, the first time in history that such a feat has been accomplished. The Yankees went on to beat the L.A. Dodgers, 8-4.

22, 1963- Over 225,000 students boycott Chicago schools in a massive protest of *de facto* segregation.

29, 1969- The U.S. Supreme Court ruled unanimously that school districts must end racial segregation " at once."

29, 1974- Muhammed Ali powers over George Foreman in an eighth round KO to regain the Heavyweight Boxing Championship.

Sources: Before the Mayflower, Lerone Bennett, Jr.; Chronology of the African-American, Alton Hornsby.

U.S. News

Thomas Trouble

Supreme Court justice, Clarence Thomas, has recently been accused of ethical breaches and federal violations. In the past six months, he has made speeches to various conservative organizations, several of which have "ambitious legal agendas." At least one of these organizations had also filed a brief in a case pending before the court.

In April, Thomas made a television appearance praising the founder of the Free Congress Foundation, an organization that brings together conservative religious groups to work for causes such as stopping abortions. During this time Free Congress had a brief filed supporting a church "in a case raising questions of freedom of speech and religion." The court unanimously decided in favor of the church, and as a result legal ethics experts accused Thomas of breaching judicial ethics and violating a federal law, which states that a judge shall disqualify himself from a case where his impartiality is questioned.

Thomas has declined to comment on the criticisms; however, Free Congress supporters assert that "Justice Thomas is taking a consistent approach based on sincerely held principles."

FACULTY CORNER

Charles H. Nichols and the Beginnings of Afro-American Studies at Brown

by Rhett S. Jones

In 1968, African American male students enrolled at Brown, and the African American female students enrolled at Pembroke-the two institutions were then gender segregated-walked off campus. Striking photographs show them walking, carrying small suitcases and books, down the hill on Angell Street. They did not have to walk far. They were received generously by the congregation of Congdon Street Baptist Church, one of Providence's historic black churches.

They demanded that Brown give more attention to the life, history, and culture of African Americans. They asked that the University increase the number of black undergraduates, black graduate students, black staff, and black faculty. They also asked that Brown establish a Black Studies Program.

As a result of their efforts, Brown's Afro-American Studies Program was founded in 1968. In that same year, Professor Charles H. Nichols, who had earned his doctorate at Brown, taught at Hampton College, the Free University of Berlin, and Grinnell College, agreed to return to the University as Professor of English and the first Director of the University's Afro-American Studies Program.

To support Professor Nichols in his work Brown established the Afro-American Studies Planning Committee, composed of faculty, members of the deanery, undergraduates, and one (lonely) Graduate student. In an early meeting of this Committee, Professor made clear his goals. First, he intended to build a black studies program that would meet and exceed the standards of teaching and research in other departments at Brown. Second, he vigorously argued, such a program should work with Providence's African American Community on issues of common interest and concern.

In the fall of 1969, Professor Nichols established the "Community Relations Seminar" in which about 30 Brown undergraduates enrolled. The seminar met once a week in Bigelow Lounge. Each week, Providence's black leaders came to discuss with students issues, problems, and opportunities in the community. Some gave formal addresses. Others talked more informally. The encounters were always probing, lively, and exciting, if sometimes argumentative. As students worked on their research reports and papers they learned from these community leaders and from one another.

Professor Nichols is now Emeritus Professor of English. His many publications include Many Thousands Gone: The Ex-slaves' Account of their Bondage and Freedom, Black Men in Chains: Narratives of Escaped Slaves, and Arne Bontemps—Langston Hughes: Letters, 1925-1967. He reviews request for faculty grants for the Center for the Study of Race and Ethnicity in America, is a strong, continuing, and aggressive supporter of the Afro-American Studies Program, and remains active in the life of the University.

Without his efforts there would be no black studies program at Brown, nor would there be the present good working relationship between the program and community, Professor Nichols laid a foundation on which all committed to African American Studies and the African American community continue to build.

Rhett S. Jones is Professor of History and Afro-American Studies. He was the (lonely) graduate student representative on the African American Studies Planning Committee in 1969. He is willing to submit short articles on blacks at Brown since 1969, but only if readers of the African Sun are interested in reading them.

FREE YOUR MIND...

With her latest book, Jazz, Toni Morrison has extended the boundaries of the genre of Black literature, defying the limits of Black scholarship within America and winning the most prestigious of literary awards, The Nobel Prize. And it's about time! Morrison is only the third woman in the history of the award to win the Nobel, and regrettably, the first African American woman. Hopefully, she will be followed in the near future.

Morrison is one of the most distinguished novelists in American literature and arguably the most important of our time. Her novel, Beloved, which won the 1988 Pulitzer Prize, has earned its place among the master works of world literature for its penetrating depiction of Sethe, an escaped slave woman dealing the trauma of spiritual and physical slavery. Sula, a tale of womanhood and self-pride, is a testament to Morrison's ability to weave a tale around the tragedies and shortcomings of human essence. Song of Solomon is also notable as an important work, expanding Morrison's skill of realistically depicting people as living and breathing souls. In an age where authors are easily and systematically altered into screenplay writers, where Danielle Steele's trashy romance and John Grisham's upper class drivel top the New York Time's Bestseller list, it is certainly refreshing to see that someone is creating pivotal works, masterpieces to be remembered forever.

-Jeffrey Penn '97

"If I'm standing, I'm loitering.... If I'm walking, I'm prowling...If I'm running, I'm escaping"

My boy Jacques and I were returning from New York City on a Monday morning a few weeks ago. 10 minutes after we entered Rhode Island we saw a police car parked on the side of the road about 100 yards ahead of us. Knowing that we were suspects of anything and everything simply because of our skin color, we slowed down a little, to a respectable 65 miles per hour, allowing cars all around us to pass as if we were standing still. As we predicted, the police cruiser began to follow us, disregarding all of the cars that sped by. For two miles we were followed as we inched along I-95 at 55 miles per hour.

After a few minutes we were pulled over. The two officers timidly approached the car with their hands on their guns. One asked for Jacques' registration and license, the other told me to get out of the car in a hostile manner. I reached for my boots, but I suppose that this was too threatening an action, because he yelled "Get out now!" Standing on the side of the road in my socks, he searched my body thoroughly. He then told me to sit down, as they checked Jacques' identification. In 15 minutes they returned, once again with hands on guns, and told us both to get out of the car. They asked if we had ever been arrested, and then told us to spread our legs and put our hands on the hood. Jacques was searched and I was searched again. At this point two other squad cars approached, one with a police dog barking like mad. For the next hour we stood on the side of the highway being barked at by the dog, and being eyed suspiciously by three cops, as a forth searched the car from top to bottom. She searched inside my Vitamin-C bottle which was in the bottom of my bag. She searched inside Jacques' remote control car. She searched the used Kleenex on the dash board. She searched the ice that remained in my McDonalds' soda cup. She searched my boots, and she searched Jacques dirty clothes. Then she searched the trunk. Finally, she summarily said "you can go." We both agreed that if they had found as much as a pocket knife in the car we were going to jail. In fact, we were quite surprised that we didn't go to jail for no reason at all. After all, we were detained, suspected, and searched for no reason at all. We were suspects and would be for the rest of our lives, and we knew this. No matter what we do with our futures we will be criminals unless otherwise proven, period. We are members of the most despised group of people in this nation, always will be, and that's that.

I had a similar experience in Providence four days earlier, and have had several other like experiences up and down the East Coast over the past three or four years. For some reason this hit me harder though, possibly because of a conversation I had this summer. I was talking about race with a co-worker of mine from South Africa,and at one point he said "Black men are under attack all over this country (America) ... no one is safe." Considering the oppressive history of his country, this statement is both powerful and extremely frightening. Regardless of how much progress we as a people have made throughout our history in this nation, the struggle continues. We can't get too comfortable. -Jeremi Duru ''95

It's A Black Thang:
Infected Social Sexual Relations at Brown

Having recently been confronted with an incident demonstrating the blatant disrespect of a Black woman by a Black man on campus, I am pressed to address this issue. Heterosexual Black men at Brown make a number of assumptions about Black women and act and get away with behavior that should under no circumstances be tolerated. It is time for Black women and men to throw down the pretence and to finally come together in honesty to discuss the present status of male/female social-sexual relations at Brown.

The first issue that needs to be addressed is the sexual objectification of Black women. When we say that we want men to be direct with us, do we mean we want them to proposition us in crass and disrespectful ways? Do we really want to know what goes on when the boys are gathered around discussing their fantasies? Or would we prefer men to present themselves as respectful of us as individuals, all the while thinking of the best possible means of getting with us? What is most disturbing about this is the basic premise or underlying assumption that all Black men sexually objectify Black women, whether direct or indirect. I understand the evils of generalization, but when the individuals who are allowed to represent Black men in a public forum, behave with disrespect toward Black women in their private lives, a generalization is justified. In such a case, there is no difference between public and private spheres. Leaders in our community should be held accountable for their behavior at all hours, especially when words and actions contradict themselves.

Another interesting thing to point out is the tendency of Black women to keep incidents of misconduct toward them by Black men within the community. It is amazing to consider the discrepancy between reported cases when divided along racial lines. So if the Black community thinks that it can heal itself without intervention, it has to be more selective in who it looks to for the initiation of the healing process.

How can Black men expect us to support and respect them, if that support and respect is not reciprocated? Can we believe you when you call us Sisters? If there really were a salvagable community of Brothers and

Sisters, we should all drop the ego and the image and throw down. You can't heal a gaping wound without the pain from the antiseptic and the stitches. It's time we close this up because we are becoming vulnerable to other infection.

-A Concerned Sister

Black and Male at Brown

In "It's A Black Thang," A Concerned Sister touches on the troubled state of gender and sexual politics in the Black community at Brown. Too often in my Brown career, the discourse on these politics has been dominated by Black women, with little to no participation from Black men. This has resulted in a problematic construction of Black men at Brown, unresolved hostilities between Black men and Black women in our community, and silence around the issues which divide Black men on this campus. Therefore, I speak to you now as a Black Gay man who is tired of the nonsense which paralyzes brothers on this campus, and who wants to see some change in two arenas: Black women's treatment of Black men, and Black men's behavior towards each other.

In regards to the status of Black men at Brown, the first thing that peeves me to no end is the lack of respect and support that is afforded to Black men by some heterosexual Black women. I cannot even begin to count the number of times that I have heard heterosexual sisters utter with the utmost conviction that "Black men are dogs... Black men ain't shit... all the good Black men are taken." With these attitudes, some straight Black women unjustly construct Black men as a monolithic breed of ill-mannered, no-count dogs. This is problematic because contrary to popular belief, there are some heterosexual Black men who respect and love their Black sisters (not all of them approach Black women in the P.O. and make lascivious proposals). These heterosexual brothers should not have to bear the stigma against Black men that is generated by the irresponsibility of a few canines. Furthermore, these attitudes reflect the heterosexist presumptions made among straight Black women in discourses on gender and sexuality. Clearly Gay Black men are not to blame for the doggish actions of some heterosexual brothers, yet we are still implicated in the all-encompassing, over-generalized indictment of Black men by straight Black women.

On a broader sociopolitical tip, some Black women at Brown condescendingly doubt the legitimacy of the developmental concerns of Black men, not understanding that Black men have "issues" too. Some sisters self-righteously demand the examination and redress of their oppression along gender and racial lines, but belittle a similar analysis of the effects of gender and race on Black men. While I would never try to devalue the struggles and triumphs of Black women, I do feel that some Black women try to prioritize their plight over that of Black men. Such prioritizing creates divisiveness and devalues the serious problems facing Black men today. In case you did not know:

- Black men comprise only 6% of the U.S. population, but account for half the male inmates in local, state, and federal prisons;
- 32% of Black men have incomes below the poverty level;
- 50% of Black men under 21 are unemployed;
- Black male babies have the lowest birth weights and the highest infant mortality rates;
- Suicide is the third leading cause of death among young Black men;
- 1 out of every 21 Black males between the ages of 15 and 34 will be killed by Black-on-Black homicide.[1]

I do not offer these statistics to say that the plight of Black men is any more pressing than that of Black women. I am merely asserting that Black men have problems, too. It is important for Black women to acknowledge this, and to grant us the space to deal with these problems.

Besides the lack of respect and support from some Black women, the second frustrating dynamic about being Black and male at Brown is the lack of respect between Black men on campus. Many of the brothers at Brown hide out in little cliques, from which they project an image of masculinity that is founded on a hard-core-street-corner-B-Boy sensibility, and/or a pseudo-Black-nationalist-self-righteousness. Thus a narrow and reductive prescription for Black masculinity is established, and barriers are raised between brothers who fit the prescription and those who fall short of it. As one who has never lived up to such macho constructions of masculinity (can you even imagine me tryin' to be "hard?"), I was written off as a punk by some brothers from the moment I got here. To this day, there are still some brothers on this campus, mostly football players and greeks, who have yet to speak to me, even when I look them dead in the eye and say "what's up?" And when I came out... damn! I couldn't believe the cold-shoulders I got from some Black men; cold-shoulders which I continue to get even today.

Now granted, I can understand why anyone would be initially intimidated by such a fierce faggot as myself (*you go, Ed*), but the silly reactions that I continue to receive from some cadres of Black men on this campus are tired and played. I am definitely down for Black male unity, but not at the expense of my Gay identity, which in fact is inseparable from my Blackness. So listen up, Black men: I refuse to be fazed by homphobic glares from brothers at Funk Nite while I'm "giving diva" on the windowsill; I refuse to be fazed by Black male D.J.'s who play homophobic Buju Banton songs at Funk Nite; I refuse to be fazed by condescending stares while I'm "giving drag queen" in the Gate; and I refuse to be fazed by silly little boys who are too insecure about their own sexuality to deal maturely with the explicitness of my homoerotic poetry at Kulcha Kollectiv's After Dark. So get over it, Negroes. I am a Black Gay man, I am your brother. If you can't look me in the eye and acknowledge me as such, then you are the punk, not I. Shit... don't hate me 'cause I'm beautiful (SNAP!).

To conclude, I hope that brothers and sisters in the Black community seriously consider the things that I've said in this piece. I admit that I do not know every side to the story of gender and sexual politics in the Black community, and therefore implore others to let their voices be heard on this topic. However, there is no doubt whatsoever in my mind that the community as a whole will never be able to advance and grow if Black men's issue remain unattended to. Black women, I ask that you be patient as Black men confront the issues that face us, and that you support us in making a space for that process. Black men, I ask that we be honest with ourselves about our attitudes towards and relationships with each other, and I encourage us to use the Brotherhood as one means of doing so.

Brothers, too many of us are still acting like little boys. It's time for us to think and behave like strong Black men.

-Ed Brockenbrough '95

1. Statistics from Michael Dyson's article "Tangled roots of an urban epidemic," Chicago Tribune, 8 July 1993, Sec. 1, p. 19.

Announcements...

The **African Heritage Coordination Committee** is a group founded by and composed of inmates at the Old Colony Correctional Institution. The new chairman, Andre Norman, is recruiting volunteers from outside the prison, who are interested in the committee's activities and development. Volunteers are welcome to initiate and run new programs of his or her own design, or simply come to an occasional meeting to listen and offer support. Everyone is welcome. If you are interested or have questions or suggestions, contact Morgan Zalkin and Sydney Evans at Brown University P.O. Box 4025, or call them at 401-274-8127. There are also fliers around campus which provide further information.

*Presenting **Cultural Commotion:** a multi-cultural night of open-mic. Bring your song, dance, music, stories, poems, or just yourself. All students, faculty, and friends welcome. The event will be held at the Production Workshop (Young Orchard St., Next to Orwig Library) on Saturday, October 30th at 8pm. If you want to perform or need more information, please contact Brian (x5462) or Joanna (274-7147). Please spread the word.

* Don't forget about the traditional Black worship services held in Manning Chapel every Sunday at 6:30!

***Voices of Inspiration** will hold a concert on November 20 in Manning Chapel. The time will be announced at a later date.

***Black Experience Weekend** is coming up (November 13). There is a desperate need for hosts. If you are able to host a perspective and have not yet signed up, please contact Karen Alexander (x5605) or Andrea Anderson (x5905).

*On Sunday, November 7, from 10:00 am until 5:30 pm, Brown University will be having its first **Black Family Reunion** for the entire community. Be there for a celebration of African-American culture, knowledge, food, and fun. The Black Family Reunion will be held at the Rites and Reasons Theatre on 155 Angel Street. Child care will be provided. For more information, call Dean Leonard Perry at (x2580).

*Harambee House's lounge is now open to the Black Community at large. While many organizations have taken advantage of the lounge, not many students have utilized the space. Fell free to stop by Harambee House lounge everyday from 7pm to 12am for a study session or a study break.

*Harambee House and Kulcha Kollectiv will be co-sponsoring an open mike jam session on November 14 for Black Experience Weekend. If you have a song to sing, a dance to perform, or a poem ya wish to read, please contact Abigail Ramsay (x5516) or Cathia Rene (x5522).

*Remember: the deadline for the November issue is October 29!

*The Harambee House Library/Artwork committee is looking for artistic talent to paint a mural on an expanse of wall. Interested aristists should submit a sample mural, via Shinina Butler Box 2013 or Jarita Davis Box 5692, by November 10, 1993. If there are any questions please contact either Shinina or Jarita, x5545.

O.U.A.P. Announcements...

*A reminder about the O.U.A.P. meeting schedule. The next three general body meetings of the semester will be held in the Harambee House lounge. The dates of these meetings are:

November 7
November 21
December 5

***Black Solidarity Day** is November 1. The plans for this year are still in the works, so keep a look out for further information.

*A forum co-sponsored by O.U.A.P. and T.N.T. will be held on Wednesday, October 27, at 7:30 in the Third World Center. The movie "Tongues Untied" will be shown, a discussion will follow.

*A.A.S.A & S.O.CA announce the upcoming Ebony Soiree to be held on December 4th. Go enjoy an evening of music, cultural presentations, and African, Caribbean, and Soul food. Stay tuned for details...

Forum : Brown , J-Dub and RISD

"Things That Divide Us, Striving To Create Solidarity"

November 1, Salomon Hall - 8pm

BLACK SOLIDARITY DAY - BE THERE!!!!!

Black Solidarity Day is a day for Black people to begin to come together as a community and begin to celebrate our similarities as well as our diversity. It is a time when we begin to build our bridges so that one day we will be able to become economically independent and be the self sufficient community that we strive to be. We at Brown must continue to try to reach this goal. It is important that Once we graduate we play an intricate role in the economic upliftment of the black community. But before we can achieve economic upliftment, we must first unify as a people.

In order to begin thinking about economic and social solidarity we will be celebrating Black Solidarity Day , Nov. 1st, with a forum between the Black communities of Johnson and Wales, Brown and RISD. This is being done in order to begin building stronger bonds as a people within the college community, so that when we leave we will be able to better work towards our goals of economic, spiritual, and social solidarity for the future. It is very important that we receive total support from the three Black communities at large.

-Zawadi Powell '96 and Monique Bobb '96 Co-Historians - Harambee House

Submit To *Uwezo*, The Magazine of Black Artistic Expression

Uwezo is the magazine of Blacks arts at Brown. Published once each semester, *Uwezo* gives members of the Brown Black community a space for expression that very few other campus outlets offer.

Uwezo is now taking submissions for the issue to be published at the end of this semester. Share the fruits of your personal expression with the rest of the community. Any form of two-dimensional, printable art— plays, stories, photographs, drawings, etc.— is acceptable. Submissions should be placed in box 79 in the Student Activity Office , or the *Uwezo* box in the Third World Center.

Those interested in participating in the production of *Uwezo* can call Abigail Ramsay x5516, Alexis Stodghill x4171, or Chris Myers x6242 for more details.

With your contributions and support, *Uwezo* will be a success!

Corrections...

•Yulisa Cruz (x6468) is the contact person for the Pan-Hellenic Council.
•Nicole Clement (x6418) is the contact person for Black Voices Alafia.
•Ray Fraser's, the contact person for the Omega Psi Phi Fraternity, Inc., correct phone number is 861-4182.

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